



PROF. PREM KUMAR DHUMAL

Hon'ble Chief Minister, Himachal Pradesh

In conversation with **Shri. Prem Kumar Dhumal**, Chief Minister who is going to complete two years as Chief Minister for second term on various facets.

- **Recent independent studies by different organisations have voted Himachal Pradesh among the best state in the country. What do you ascribe this success to?**

It became possible due to the developmental and welfare oriented policies being pursued by the Government in the state, especially in last 22 months. The present state government has given added priority for speedy and uniform development of the state and also for the betterment of the common man. The Government is ensuring self-dependence, self-respect and abundant employment opportunities to the people of the State. Besides effective governance, the people are also giving their wholehearted cooperation to make the Government's policies and welfare programmes a success. The state government officers and employees also deserve appreciation for implementing the policies of the Government in the right perspective that has made this progress possible.

- **How do you explain the phenomenal success of Himachal Pradesh in the field of education and primary health?**

There has been spectacular progress in the field of education, health and other sectors. According to 2001 census, Himachal Pradesh has a literacy percentage of 77.13 which is much higher than the national average. It also has the highest enrolment rate of more than 20 percent in higher education against the national average of 10 percent. The Government is making an effort to ensure this enrolment rate to rise to 50 per cent in next few years. There is a network of over 16,000 educational institutions in the state which includes three universities, two medical colleges and one engineering college and also, a large number of other technical institutions. We intend to make Himachal Pradesh the educational hub of the country soon. We plan to open 16 universities in near future. Since we came into power, two universities of international standard have already been set up. We are in process to set up seven more universities

and seven more proposals have been received which are also being looked into.

'Atal Shiksha Kunj' is being set up near Baddi in Solan district on public-private partnership. Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) has been set up in Mandi district where the first batch has been enrolled. Other universities that are in the process of being set up are Central University near Dehra in Kangra district, International university at Badu Shahib in Sirmour district and Arni University Kathgarh in Mand area of Kangra district. The National Institute of Fashion Technology (NIFT) near Cheb in Kangra district has also been set up in record time of six months.

In the health sector, we have appointed over 400 new doctors and posted them in remote districts of the state so that people get better health care facilities at their door-step. Hundreds of medical and para-medical staff have been appointed and posted in rural areas. Besides the existing medical colleges namely Indira Gandhi Medical College and Hospital in Shimla and Dr. Rajendera Prasad College and Hospital, Tanda (Kangra), three medical colleges-cum-hospitals are also opened. The work on a ESI Hospital-cum-Medical College in Mandi District has begun. The Health Insurance Scheme has been introduced for the poor for whom they do not have to pay any premium.

- **As this is your second stint as Chief Minister of Himachal Pradesh, what are your priorities in this tenure which may have left undone in your last term?**

The top priority is to make Himachal Pradesh an ideal, developed, self-dependent and self-sufficient state, where there are ample opportunities of self-employment. 'Subse Upar Himachal', 'Swablamban' and 'Swarojgar' are the objectives on which we are working. Education, health and road connectivity has been given additional attention. We are also trying to generate resources for the state by exploiting the hydel, tourism and industrial potential.

Providing responsive, transparent and efficient governance is our priority. Our efforts in this respect have been appreciated, especially in respect of 'Prashashan Janata Ke Dewar' or e-governance for which the state has been given the Best State award.

- **Though a hilly state, many investors are finding Himachal a safe place for investment. What is the reason for this?**

Investor friendly, transparent and responsive administration, dust-free and peaceful environment are the advantages that investors find in Himachal Pradesh to set up their ventures. Besides, we have set up a Single Window Clearance and Monitoring Authority under the chairmanship of Chief Minister to accord approvals for setting up of industrial units in the State. The investors don't have to go from pillar to post to get clearances. All clearances are given by this authority. We are also creating basic infrastructure to facilitate the investors. Road and communication networks are also improved to avoid inconvenience to the investors. The incentives given by the state for setting up of new ventures is the best. There is also abundant supply of electricity which is cheapest in our country.

- **Are there any innovative management practices that you have adopted that helped you achieve this success?**

E-Governance has been given special emphasis by the Government. This has helped in avoiding delays and quick delivery of goods. Himachal Pradesh has received an award for adopting this innovative system of governance. We have also adopted the system of 'e-samadhan' which is helping the people in getting speedy justice. As stated earlier, we have adopted the system of 'Prashashan Janta Ke Dewar' to solve the grievances and problems of the people. I, along with my colleagues, visit the sites and the secretaries and senior officials also join us. We organise 'Prashashan Janta Ke Dewar' in the District, Sub-Divisional Tehsil and Block Level to solve the problems and grievances of the people.

- **The state website says you have been often called 'Sadakwala Mukhyamantri' for your obsession of improving the roads in the state. How do you react to this?**

I am grateful to the people for having recognised my contribution for road connectivity in Himachal. Provision of proper road connectivity has been added priority during last tenure as well as present tenure. The state